

HIMACHAL PRADESH



PREM KUMAR DHUMAL
CHIEF MINISTER

"The proposals are a source of worry. Ours is the most debt-distressed state. We need a Central bail-out to implement it."

BIHAR



NITISH KUMAR
CHIEF MINISTER

"It would be early to speak on this issue. Let the Centre take a decision first on the commission's recommendations."

ARMED FORCES: TOO LITTLE, TOO LATE

Huge hikes for greenhorns will make the forces attractive but not enough to retain the

The armed forces hoped the Sixth Pay Commission would improve their attractiveness, increase their retainability and reduce the deficiency in the officer corps. These are three of the biggest problems the world's second largest armed forces are grappling with and yet the report has addressed only the first problem. A hike of over 60 per cent for young officers has somewhat levelled the playing field in the hunt for young talent and in reducing a shortage of nearly 12,000 young officers. However, a modest hike for mid-level officers like Lt-colonels, colonels and brigadiers—from where the exodus is taking place—means nearly half the army's officer corps feels left out. A paltry pay hike for soldiers (they will get a military service pay of only

Rs 1,000) is a reflection of how there is no shortage of aspirants for persons below officer rank. The new running pay band means the service chiefs, now treated on par with the cabinet secretary, will get huge pay hikes amounting to Rs 90,000 per month.

The commission has recommended a military service pay of Rs 6,000 per month for officers and lateral absorption of retired personnel of armed forces into the paramilitary forces (the armed forces retire their personnel earlier). However, the proposed pay hike will create fresh inequalities.

A young lieutenant now earning

Rs 8,250 will receive Rs 25,760 or a pay hike of over 60 per cent. However, his commanding officer, a colonel with 19 years of service, will take home only Rs 44,140. The running pay band has also triggered angst because most of the armed forces' personnel will continue to draw lower pay through their career. Almost all civil servants will reach the rank of joint secretary in 16-17 years service and remain in the

higher pay band for a period of another 20 years. On the other hand, approximately 87 per cent of armed forces' officers will never rise to the equivalent rank of major general.

The commission has recommended a significant improvement in terminal benefits—gratuity has been raised from Rs 3.5 lakh to Rs 10 lakh. The

underlying message to the armed forces is "come join us if you have it in you. Serve for 20 years and then go fend for yourselves", says Major General Surjit Singh (retired).

The commission is silent on short service commissions, something critical for ensuring the army can fill in vacant slots and has shot down the one-rank-one pension scheme which figured in the UPA's election manifesto and was meant to redress the imbalance between retired personnel. The forecast is that after the initial euphoria, old problems will return to haunt the armed forces.

by Sandeep Unnithan

WAGE WISE

- Huge pay hike for young officers, army commanders and chief; only modest increase in mid-levels
- Paltry hike for soldiers, persons below officer rank
- Running pay band for officers
- No to one-rank one-pay

Delhi with a sprawling garden maintained by the Public Works Department!

All this for not even working a full year! With a five-day week, a government servant gets 104 holidays straight. Add three national holidays, 14 gazetted holidays, two restricted holidays, eight days of casual leave, 30 days of earned leave and 20 days of half-pay leave. If an employee takes all the leave, he will be at work for only 184 days. Assuming he doesn't take the half-pay leave, he will work for 206 days only. Sure the Sixth Pay Commission has advocated the abolition of gazetted holidays, has recommended three national holi-

days and eight restricted ones. This will possibly be the first casualty in the list of proposals. Leave alone abolishing holidays, in the run-up to the polls, the states and the Centre will compete to announce religious holidays.

The point is not the pay but the promise of non-performance. There is no accountability, bar the Right to Information Act (RTI) and no mechanism for redress. A citizen can approach a court against a babu for wrong doing. But there is no law to ensure he performs. It is not just Chidambaram who has been lamenting about outlays and outcomes. For years now on every rupee spent towards